Understanding Analysis, 2nd Edition
Chapter 7 - Section 7.3 - Integrating Functions with Discontinuities

1. Straightforward.

2. Recall the Thomae's function

$$t(x) = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } x = 0 \\ 1/n & \text{if } x = m/n \in \mathbf{Q}\backslash\{0\} \text{ is in lowest terms with } n > 0 \\ 0 & \text{if } x \notin \mathbf{Q} \end{cases}$$

has a countable set of discontinuities occurring at precisely every rational number. Follow these steps to prove that $t(x)$ is integrable on $[0, 1]$ with $\int_0^1 t = 0$.

   (a) First argue that $L(t, P) = 0$ for any partition P of $[0, 1]$.

   (b) Let $\epsilon > 0$ and consider the set of points $D_{\epsilon/2} = \{x \in [0, 1] : t(x) \geq \epsilon/2\}$. How big is $D_{\epsilon/2}$?

   (c) To complete the argument, explain how to construct a partition P_ϵ of $[0, 1]$ so that $U(t, P_\epsilon) < \epsilon$.

Solution:

(a) By the density of the irrationals, every interval in P contains an irrational number, which makes the infimum in the interval 0.

(b) It's finite. Let n be the largest natural number such that $\frac{1}{n} \geq \frac{\epsilon}{2}$. Then $D_{\epsilon/2}$ consists of x such that $t(x) = \frac{1}{k}$ with $k \leq n$. There are only finitely many k and for each k, there are only finitely many such x.

A concrete example, suppose $k = 4$. How many x are there such that $t(x) = \frac{1}{4}$? There are only 2, $x = \frac{1}{4}$ and $x = \frac{3}{4}$. For $x = \frac{4}{4}$, $t(x) = 1$ and once the numerator goes past 4, we're already outside the $[0, 1]$ domain.

In general, the number of x such that $t(x) = \frac{1}{k}$ is at most $k + 1$ because there are only $k + 1$ candidates in $[0, 1]$: $\frac{0}{k}$ up to $\frac{k}{k}$.

(c) By part (b), there's only a finite set of rationals $R = \{r_1 = 0 < r_2 < ... < r_n = 1\}$ where $t(r_i) \geq \frac{\epsilon}{2}$. Also, since $t(x) \leq 1$ for all x, then $\frac{\epsilon}{2} \leq t(r_i) \leq 1$. The idea is to bound this finite set of large points in a small interval.

To control the interval size around the r_i's, we need to insert two points between each of them. Let $P = \{r_1, p_1, p_2, r_2, p_3, p_4, r_3, ..., r_{n-1}, p_{2n-3}, p_{2n-2}, r_n\}$. There are $2n-2$ intervals that contain r_i. Set the distance between adjacent r and p to be $< \frac{\epsilon}{4n}$. Remembering that $t(x) \leq 1$ for all x, let s_1 be the sum of all intervals that contain r_i, then

$$s_1 < (2n-2)\frac{\epsilon}{4n} < 2n\frac{\epsilon}{4n} = \frac{\epsilon}{2}$$

Now we need to consider the sum between adjacent p's. Since R contains *all* points where $t(x) \geq \frac{\epsilon}{2}$, then for $x \in [p_i, p_{i+1}]$, $x \notin R$ hence $t(x) < \frac{\epsilon}{2}$. The sum s_2 between adjacent p_i's is then

$$s_2 \leq \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} \frac{\epsilon}{2}(p_{2i} - p_{2i-1}) = \frac{\epsilon}{2}\sum_{i=1}^{n-1}(p_{2i} - p_{2i-1})$$

(we use $\leq$ because the supremum can still be $\frac{\epsilon}{2}$)

The tricky part is that we have no control over the length of individual $(p_{2i} - p_{2i-1})$. But note that since the domain is $[0, 1]$, we can conclude that the sum of interval lengths is at most 1 i.e. $\sum_{i=1}^{n-1}(p_{2i} - p_{2i-1}) \leq 1$. Then

$$s_2 \leq \frac{\epsilon}{2}\sum_{i=1}^{n-1}(p_{2i} - p_{2i-1}) \leq \frac{\epsilon}{2}$$

Finally

$$U(t, P) = s_1 + s_2 < \frac{\epsilon}{2} + \frac{\epsilon}{2} = \epsilon$$